

Tirupati Temple *Darshan*

I had two options: The first was to visit the Tirupati temple on the Tirumala Hills for *darshan* and offer *pooja* there. The second was to visit a devotional Web site, and go through the *darshan* and *pooja*—entirely online. Here's a quick look at how I went about the two contrasting, yet interesting, tasks

Rupesh Sreedharan (rupesh_sreedharan@jasubhai.com)



A view of the Balaji temple on Tirumala Hills



The home page of Eprarthana.com

1

At Borivli, a suburb in Mumbai, I spent **Rs 30**, and **90 minutes** in the queue to book a ticket to Chennai. That's **Rs 684** for the tickets. Next, **Rs 100** and **four hours** of travel to get to Cuffe Parade to set up accommodation in Tirupati. Make that **Rs 750** in room charges for the 3-day stay.

Visited the Web site eprarthana.com, which offers services for online pooja. Took a mere **five minutes** to browse to the site. I had to register first so I could proceed with the e-darshan and the e-pooja. That took **10 minutes**.

2

The train journey took me **22 hours**, not to mention miscellaneous expenditures of **Rs 200**. Hey, wait! I forgot about the return journey, so all the above prices and times have to be **multiplied by two**.

I rummaged through innumerable temples and poojas. Finally, I found the Balaji temple at Tirumala. The next step was as simple as just clicking on an 'Offer Pooja' button. I got a visual tour of the temple and its history. The charges: **Rs 275**. It took me about **15 minutes**.

3

On Sunday evening, I got hold of the arm-tag from the temple authorities. The *darshan* was on Tuesday morning. Another queue, another **three hours**. Finally, I get the much-awaited glimpse of Lord Balaji. Don't forget the **Rs 400** I spent on sustenance throughout the trip.

I settled for a credit card transaction as the mode of payment. The site offered me a transaction identification, and added the pooja I selected to my 'Pooja Cart', and I was done! Add another **five minutes** for that.

4

Whew! The entire episode cost me good money—**Rs 684** for the tickets, **Rs 750** for the stay and **Rs 930** in sundry expenses.

My condition: Exhausted and cash-strapped, but a worthwhile trip nonetheless.

It all cost me just **Rs 275**. As simple as that.

My Condition: There's nothing to complain about when offering pooja online, as long as you are aware that this is in no way the real thing.

Total Time Spent: **Four days**
Total cost: **Rs 2,364**



Total Time Spent: **35 minutes**
Total cost: **Rs 275**



AND
THE
WINNER
IS...

When it comes to convenience and cost, the tech way wins hands down. Travelling all the way to Tirupati, waiting in long queues, and then doing it all over again to come back home, is a tiring affair

indeed. I also had to take four days leave from work! However, the ambience and fulfilment after visiting the temple are unsurpassed. The tech way will never be able to replace the old way here.